TechDella

PDF-01 · CHECKLIST · 2026 EDITION

AI search readiness, *checked.*

Can AI answer engines reach your pages, understand who you are, and quote you? Fifty checks across crawler access, rendering, entity clarity, answer-first content and measurement.

FOR	TIME	YOU NEED
Marketing leads at B2B companies	About 90 minutes for a first pass	Your robots.txt, Search Console, GA4 and a list of buyer questions

START HERE

How to use this checklist

AI answer engines can only cite pages they are allowed to fetch, can read without running scripts, and can tie to a clear entity. Most of AI search readiness is good technical SEO plus content that answers questions directly.

Google says there are no extra requirements to appear in AI Overviews or AI Mode beyond being indexed and eligible to show a snippet, and that normal SEO best practices apply. Other engines (ChatGPT search, Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot, Claude) run their own crawlers or rely on a search partner's index. So the work splits into two parts: let the right bots in, and make your pages the clearest answer on the topic.

Scoring

Tick each box that is true today. Each section ends with a score line. Use the totals to choose where to start, not as a grade.

Section	What it answers	Checks
1. Crawler access	Can the AI crawlers and search bots fetch your pages?	8
2. Indexing and rendering	Can they read the content without running JavaScript, and are your snippet settings intentional?	12
3. Entity clarity	Is it obvious who you are, what you sell and who stands behind the content?	10
4. Answer-first content	Do your pages answer buyer questions in a form that is easy to quote?	12
5. Measurement	Will you know whether any of this is working?	8

BEFORE YOU START: WRITE DOWN 20 BUYER QUESTIONS

Pull them from sales calls, support tickets, Search Console queries and "People also ask". Mix category questions ("what is generative engine optimization"), comparison questions ("X vs Y for SaaS"), and buying questions ("best B2B SEO agency for fintech"). You will use this list in sections 4 and 5.

#	Buyer question	Type (category / compare / buy)	Page that should answer it
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

SECTION 1

Crawler access

Check robots.txt, then check that your CDN or firewall is not blocking the same bots silently. A bot blocked at the firewall never sees your robots.txt.

CRAWLERS TO KNOW (NAMES AS PUBLISHED BY EACH COMPANY)

User agent	Company	What it does
Googlebot	Google	Crawls for Google Search, which also feeds AI Overviews and AI Mode. Blocking it removes you from both.
Google-Extended	Google	A robots.txt token, not a separate crawler. Controls whether content Google crawls may be used for Gemini model training and grounding. Google states it does not affect Search inclusion or ranking.
Bingbot	Microsoft	Crawls for Bing, which Microsoft Copilot uses for web answers.
OAI-SearchBot	OpenAI	Surfaces sites in ChatGPT search results.
ChatGPT-User	OpenAI	Fetches a page when a ChatGPT user or GPT asks for it.
GPTBot	OpenAI	Collects content that may be used to train OpenAI models.
PerplexityBot / Perplexity-User	Perplexity	Indexing for Perplexity search results / fetching pages for a user's question.
ClaudeBot / Claude-User / Claude-SearchBot	Anthropic	Training data collection / fetching for a user's request / search indexing. [CONFIRM: current Anthropic bot names]
Applebot / Applebot-Extended	Apple	Crawling for Apple search features / a token controlling use for Apple's model training.

- ☐ **You have decided, in writing, which bots to allow.**
  A common B2B choice: allow all search and user-fetch bots, and decide separately on training-only bots (GPTBot, Google-Extended, ClaudeBot, Applebot-Extended).
- ☐ **robots.txt matches that decision** and returns HTTP 200 at `/robots.txt`.
- ☐ **No blanket `Disallow: /` under `User-agent: *`** left over from a staging site.
- ☐ **Googlebot and Bingbot can fetch your key pages.**
  Use URL Inspection in Search Console and the URL Inspection tool in Bing Webmaster Tools.
- ☐ **Your CDN or firewall's "AI bot" or "bot fight" settings match your robots.txt.**
  Some CDNs offer one-click blocking of AI crawlers, and some turn it on by default for new sites. [CONFIRM: your CDN's current default]
- ☐ **Server logs show the bots you allowed actually visiting.**
  Filter access logs by the user agents above. No visits in 30 days usually means a block somewhere.
- ☐ **Key pages return 200**, not 403 or a challenge page, to non-browser clients.
- ☐ **Your XML sitemap is listed in robots.txt** and submitted in Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools.

Score: ____ / 8

SECTION 2

Indexing and rendering

Many AI crawlers do not run JavaScript the way Googlebot does. If your answer only appears after scripts run, assume some engines never see it.

- [ ] **The main text of each key page is in the initial HTML.**
  Test: view source (not the inspector) or fetch the page with `curl`, and search for a sentence from the body.
- [ ] **Headings, lists and tables are real HTML** (`h2`, `ul`, `table`), not styled `div`s or images of text.
- [ ] **FAQs and tabs are in the HTML** even when collapsed.
  `<details>` works without scripts.
- [ ] **Each page has one self-referencing canonical URL**, and parameter variants (UTM, `?ref=`) point to it.
- [ ] **Key pages are indexed in Google and Bing.**
  Check the Pages report in Search Console and Bing's Site Explorer.
- [ ] **`nosnippet`, `max-snippet` and `data-nosnippet` are used only on purpose.**
  Google applies these controls to AI Overviews and AI Mode too; a `nosnippet` page cannot be quoted.
- [ ] **Important pages are not behind a login, a cookie wall or a form.**
- [ ] **Staging and preview sites are blocked** (password plus noindex), so engines do not cite the wrong copy.
- [ ] **No important pages are `noindex`** by mistake (common after a theme or plugin change).
- [ ] **Pages load fast on mobile**: Core Web Vitals pass in Search Console for your key templates.
- [ ] **Bing Webmaster Tools is verified**, and IndexNow (or Bing's URL submission) is set up so updates reach Bing quickly.
- [ ] **PDFs and resources you want cited have an HTML page** that summarizes them.
  Answer engines quote HTML pages more reliably than files.

Score: ____ / 12

QUICK TEST

Run `curl -sA "OAI-SearchBot" https://yoursite.com/your-key-page/ | grep -c "a sentence from your page"`. A result of 0 means the bot either got blocked or got a page without your content. Repeat with the other user agents you allow.

SECTION 3

Entity clarity

Answer engines describe companies by stitching together facts from many sources. Make those facts identical everywhere, and make it easy to connect your site, your people and your profiles.

- ☐ **One sentence says what you do**, and it is the same on your homepage, About page, LinkedIn, and directory profiles.
  Example format: "[Company] is a [category] for [audience] that [outcome]."
- ☐ **Your company name is written the same way everywhere** (capitalization, spacing, legal suffix).
- ☐ `Organization` **structured data** on the homepage includes name, URL, logo and `sameAs` links to your official profiles.
- ☐ **Structured data matches the visible page** and validates in the Rich Results Test and the Schema.org validator.
- ☐ **An About page** names the founders and team, where you work, who you serve and how to contact you.
- ☐ **Articles have named authors** with an author page (role, experience, LinkedIn) and `Person` markup.
- ☐ **Service pages name the service plainly** in the H1 and title, using the words buyers use.
- ☐ **Case studies name the client, the timeframe and the numbers**, with permission.
  Specific, attributable facts are what engines can quote.
- ☐ **Third-party profiles are complete and current**: LinkedIn company page, Google Business Profile if you have an office, and the review or directory sites your buyers use.
- ☐ **Contact details (name, address if public, phone, email) are consistent** across the site and profiles.

Score: ____ / 10

Entity fact sheet

Fact	Your exact wording
One-sentence description	
Category you want to be named in	
Primary audience	
Markets / countries served	
Founders and key people	

SECTION 4

Answer-first content

Engines pull short passages that answer the question. Put the answer in the first two or three sentences, then support it with evidence that only you have.

- ☐ **Each of your 20 buyer questions maps to one page** that answers it (from the table on page 2).
- ☐ **The answer comes first**: 40 to 60 words directly under the H1 or the matching H2, before any background.
- ☐ **Question-shaped subheadings** where they fit the reader ("How long does B2B SEO take?").
- ☐ **Definitions are self-contained**: a sentence that still makes sense when quoted on its own.
- ☐ **Comparisons are in tables** with clear row and column labels.
- ☐ **Steps are in numbered lists.**
- ☐ **Every page has something first-hand**: your numbers, a screenshot, what you did and what happened, or a clear opinion.
- ☐ **Claims link to their source**, and statistics carry a date.
- ☐ **Pages show "last updated" or "last reviewed" dates** that change only when the content does.
- ☐ **Thin and duplicate pages are merged or removed**, so one strong page answers each question.
- ☐ **Comparison and "alternatives" pages are fair**: they name where a competitor is the better fit.
- ☐ **Internal links connect each answer** to the related service page and two or three related definitions.

Score: ____ / 12

WEAK OPENING

"In today's digital landscape, more and more buyers are turning to AI tools. In this article we'll explore what generative engine optimization means for your business."

ANSWER-FIRST OPENING

"Generative engine optimization (GEO) is the work of making your content easy for AI answer engines to find, trust and quote. In practice it means crawler access, clear entity facts and pages that answer one question directly."

About llms.txt

`llms.txt` is a proposed convention (llmstxt.org) for a plain-Markdown file at your site root that summarizes your site and links to key pages. It is cheap to add. No major answer engine has publicly documented that it uses the file for ranking or citation, and Google has said it does not use it for Search. [CONFIRM: current statements from Google, OpenAI, Anthropic and Perplexity] Treat it as optional housekeeping, not a strategy.

- ☐ **Optional:** `/llms.txt` exists, lists your services and key guides with URLs, and is generated from your CMS so it stays current.

SECTION 5

Measurement

There is no single "AI rankings" report. Combine what your analytics already sees with a fixed set of prompts you check by hand every month.

- ☐ **GA4 has a channel or segment for AI referrals**: sessions with referrers such as chatgpt.com, perplexity.ai, copilot.microsoft.com, gemini.google.com and claude.ai.
- ☐ **Your CRM records "How did you hear about us?"** with an option for "ChatGPT / AI assistant".
  Many AI-influenced buyers arrive by typing your URL, so referrers undercount.
- ☐ **Search Console is reviewed monthly** for impressions and clicks on your buyer-question pages.
  Google reports AI Overviews and AI Mode traffic inside the normal Performance report, not separately. [CONFIRM: current Search Console reporting]
- ☐ **A fixed prompt set (your 20 questions) is run monthly** in Google AI Mode, ChatGPT search, Perplexity and Copilot, logged in the table below.
- ☐ **You record which competitors and which of their pages are cited**, not just whether you are.
- ☐ **Answers about your company are checked for accuracy** ("What does [Company] do?", "Who founded [Company]?").
- ☐ **Bot visits are tracked from server logs** monthly, by user agent.
- ☐ **Results are reviewed on a set date** with an owner and next actions.

Score: ____ / 8

MONTHLY PROMPT LOG

Prompt	Engine	Date	Cited? (Y/N)	Our URL cited	Competitors cited

AI answers vary between runs and between users. Run each prompt in a logged-out or fresh session, note the date, and look at trends over several months rather than single results.

YOUR RESULTS

Add it up and pick three fixes

Section	Your score	Max	Start here if…
1. Crawler access	____	8	Any box in this section is unticked. Nothing else matters until bots can reach you.
2. Indexing and rendering	____	12	Your content only appears after JavaScript runs.
3. Entity clarity	____	10	Engines describe your company wrongly or vaguely.
4. Answer-first content	____	12	You are indexed but competitors get cited for your topics.
5. Measurement	____	8	You cannot tell whether AI search sends you anything.
Total	____	50	

#	Fix	Owner	Due
1			
2			
3			

Want a second *opinion?*

Our AI search optimization work starts with this checklist, run against your site and your buyers' real questions, plus a prioritized fix list.

Request a growth audit →

techdella.com/services/ai-search-optimization/

Sources

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